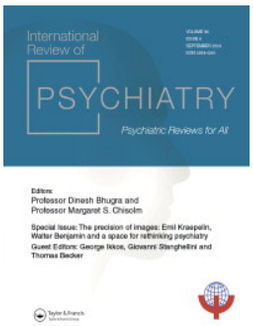

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RESEARCH ARTICLE

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The function of structuring images: the concept of epiphany from literature to psychiatry

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ABSTRACT
In the course of the psychiatrist-patient relationship, and especially during a psychotherapy, an image sometimes appears that is greeted by the therapist with a sense of surprise and rediscovery. Such an image has the quality of condensing many of the scattered elements of the patient's life and giving them a form that makes it possible to recognise something stable and permanent in the functioning of the patient's subjectivity. I propose to call these images, which have a valence of enlightenment, clarification and condensation of scattered elements, structuring images. I have used the term 'epiphany' to define these moments of enlightenment, which are of great help in psychiatric and psychotherapeutic work, contributing to a new construction of the history and relationships of the patient's life.

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Structuring images; epiphany; condensation; construction; sensoriality

Introduction

In the course of a psychiatric consultation, the assessment of a clinical history, or during a psychotherapeutic session, an image sometimes emerges.

This image may be an episode, a fantasy, a dream, a sensory detail, recounted first-hand. The important thing is that this image sheds light on a whole series of loose elements, as if it were a condensed synthesis, showing the therapist a different story from the literal narrative and opening up new perspectives.

I propose to call this aspect of enlightenment that the image brings about an 'epiphany' and to refer to this type of image as a 'structuring image'.

My aim is to explore this concept of epiphany, which originated in the fields of literature and philosophy, especially literary criticism, but which is particularly useful when applied to the context of the encounter between psychotherapist and patient.

First, I will propose a definition of the concept, then I will trace very briefly a history of its uses. I will therefore use several interpretive keys to show how the concept is suitable for highlighting certain phases of the therapeutic relationship, more precisely those in which it is necessary to engage in a new reading of episodes or events, that had previously been considered stable and consolidated.

I will then present a small number of clinical cases, in order to give a more vivid depth to the discussion.

The concept of epiphany is also closely related to that of structuring images. By structuring images as I said, I mean certain images that have appeared in dreams or as sensory data in real life. Images that have the quality of containing a whole discourse, an extended context, that sums up many of the elements of a particular kind of experience, one that takes on a recognisable form and visibility in the image itself. These images are referred to as 'structuring', insofar as they provide a frame, give a shape to a set of elements, which, when connected, offer a new aspect.

This idea is reminiscent of Lichtenberg's model scene (Lichtenberg et al., 2001), which, however, refers to an image that summarises a particular type of relationship with an object: it is, in other words, a relational scheme. Moreover, the model scene is not necessarily an image, but can also consist of a gesture, an action, or a behaviour. A structuring image is instead a sensory element, which can be real or dreamt.

The epiphany

As we know, the term derives from the Greek and means a manifestation, a light shining on something

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that offers not only itself, but also confers an entirely new interpretation and meaning to a whole.

An epiphany presents itself as an apparition, that evokes a sense both of surprise and of discovery in the listener. Something about which we might say: 'there, now I can finally understand a great many things, I can see a whole series of events, thoughts and past associations in a new light,. In short, a detail charged with an enlightening power, one that condenses multiple meanings within itself and appears to be able to sum up, synthesise and bring together details that were once scattered and disconnected into a representational unity.

Applied to literature, the term was first used by Pater (2005), a great nineteenth-century English critic and essayist. He described how in a sequence of contingent and transient events and associations, a detail may suddenly appear, usually an extremely dense image or word, which presents the reader with a sense of stability, of an interruption in the flow of time.

In Pater's vision this detail possesses its own beauty, beauty understood as an image possessing a form, capable of conferring to the image itself a sense of completeness, measuredness, proportion and radiance. According to Pater, an epiphany is a challenge to contingency and a suggestion of a stable beauty, that finally defeats time and allows a contemplative, pleasant and peaceful rest, after an exhausting meandering without a specific destination.

Umberto Eco in particular, in a book dedicated to James Joyce, is credited with showing how this concept was used extensively by the Irish author, especially in his short stories set in Dublin (Eco, 1966). In each short story of *Dubliners*, Joyce chooses a detail, whose appearance sheds a light on a whole series of occurrences and finally provides an interpretive key to all the previous events.

The detail that 'presentifies' the epiphany conveys a sense of surprise, but also of openness, discovery, expansion. It can be the scene of a departure or a payment or a sudden longing or a missed appointment.

In the context of the epiphany these details go beyond themselves. They become metaphors of distance, or of the difficulty of loving, of a past regret, and they have unexpected overtones. In other words, the epiphany broadens the scope of a story, but also presentifies a major philosophical and human theme: contingency, loss, idealisation, vulgarity, decline.

But these main themes are not mere generalisations. They shed light on a particular story, they situate it in a personal affair, they historicise it: they are details that spill into the general, while still remaining details.

The idea of epiphany seems to me to be particularly useful when transferred to the psychiatric sphere, and more specifically to psychotherapy.

Patients often offer a stereotyped image of themselves, an identity that manifests itself as a sort of tailor-made suit. Or, on the contrary, they often bring disordered and confused material to sessions, which hinders any synthesis, and therefore diagnosis, in the psychodynamic sense. In these contexts, an image may suddenly appear, which stands out from the others, because it seems to have a strong explanatory and at the same time condensing power. An image that is a discourse, that is in itself a story, but enclosed within the image itself.

This point should be explored further.

The characteristics of an epiphany

A first characteristic of an epiphany is the fact that it is an image, a detail that imposes itself on the senses, as well as on the mind or on verbal discourse.

Two elements, I hope, will help to clarify this point.

Discussing the interpretation of dreams, Freud (Freud, 1900) cautions against being seduced by what he calls secondary processing, i.e. the narrative form the dream takes after waking, when we try to impose an order onto the dream and turn it into a story. Freud says that such an operation is defensive. What is important is the single image, which is certainly part of the dream, but which also maintains a poignancy, a specificity, of its own.

If the dreamer dreams of a face covered with long, dishevelled hair, it is not only the place that this image occupies in the dream that matters, but even more so what this long hair covering the face might actually be, what story it tells, what character it shows, what secret it reveals.

This example will help us to be even more specific.

The patient who shared this dream has the great problem of constantly having to show her strength, abilities and independence. To do this, she has to control her emotions, especially the painful and sad ones, so as not to appear weak and not self-sufficient.

The image of her hair-covered face suggests her urge to hide her face so as not to show her pain or her tears, but at the same time it evokes a display of mourning, of disarray, of a lack of control over that dishevelled hair. So, in order to hide her emotions too much, she shows them up in different ways.

Achieving this requires knowledge of the patient's history on the part of the therapist, but also an informed use of the imagination. Imagination, in this sense, is the ability to focus on the image, to question it, to expand it, always with the historical context as a guide, not the unbridled fancy of the therapist, which can be misleading.

In this perspective, the image becomes a discourse and the sensoriality a proposed narrative of reality through other means.

It is possible to reintegrate this theme into the broader theme of construction.

Freud suggested that in psychoanalytic work we should alternate between moments of interpretation and moments of construction (Freud, 1937). Interpretation broadens a detail, shows it from a new angle, offers a different point of view.

Construction, on the other hand, is the story of a sequence in the patients' life, told in a way they have never told it to themselves and that emerges from certain details, from an unexpected image which, as it were, tells a different story.

If we question the image, we can perceive a narrative that will unfold in terms other than those that have become standardised and fixed in the patient's memory.

We could say that one of the aims of psychoanalysis is to construct a story of patients, other than the narratives they have always repeated to themselves. But this is not possible without the epiphanic appearance of an important image.

Carlo Ginzburg (Ginzburg, 1979) offers us another element with his work on the 'Paradigma indiziario' (Circumstantial Paradigm). In this notable book, Ginzburg compares the work of the therapist to that of Sherlock Holmes, who reconstructs an entirely different possible story of how things really happened, starting from a particular detail noticed at the scene of the crime (Stanghellini 1979, in press).

The two phenomena seem to go hand in hand.On the one hand the image tells a story, on the other the story leaves traces, signs, which, if put together, tell us something more.

Epiphany and sensoriality

It is widely accepted today that sensoriality, that is sensory data, cannot converge entirely into the words of a language (Correale 2021).

On the one hand, words expand, provide an order, specify, organise things spatially and temporally. On the other, they partially dilute the power of an image, limit its explanatory and communicative potential. Of course, the opposite can also happen: images may also be rhetorical, redundant, hypertrophic, excessive and impede access to language.

But if we look more deeply at the value of the sensoriality of an image, without being blinded by its power, as is often the case in the contemporary world, in what I have called hypnotising images, we realise that the image returns us to a primordial sensoriality. In this perspective, the body of the mother is no longer merely a body, but a cluster of sensations: soft/hard, hot/cold, tall/short, widening/constriction, speeding up/slowing down.

In sum, according to this primordial component of the image, every image seems capable of modifying the spatiotemporal coordinates of its recipient, without the power of its content being forgotten (Merleau-Ponty 1964).

On this point phenomenology and psychoanalysis meet.

Phenomenology speaks of the pre-categorical. I believe that this refers more or less to something that resonates within the subject as some very physical, almost material characteristics of the object.

Two joined hands do not only tell each other that they are two hands, but convey something like a time standing still, a space that becomes warmth or softness, as if the physics of the outside became a physics of the inside.

Something similar occurs in Freud's child sexuality (Freud 1905). The swallowing mouth is not only an absorbing, an internalising and an incorporating entity, but it also modifies the inside/outside, subject/other relationship, following a physical, bodily and sensorial rhythm.

But let us return to the epiphany and therefore to the structuring image.

I hope I have been able to show, however briefly and concisely, that the epiphany consists in the appearance of an image with special powers, related to presenting a subject-object relationship with extremely ancient and original spatio-temporal characteristics, which is finally revealed in the image itself.

I think this is what Ricoeur (Ricoeur1975) had in mind, when he spoke of 'living metaphors'. Images possessing an explanatory power, which draw on the primal, in contrast to all the images that do not point to this path, but allow themselves to be dragged away by rhetoric.

What we mean by rhetoric here, is clearly the phenomenon whereby the goal of persuasion takes precedence over everything else, to the serious detriment of the explanatory power of the image itself.

In the last of the short stories that make up Joyce's *Dubliners*, for example, the River Shannon and its ceaselessly flowing waters expand the discourse on love into a discourse on time and the human condition.

It also needs to be added that what we have said so far also applies to hallucinatory images and those that arise in acute psychosis. In the case of hallucinations, the image may take on a fixed character, as if carved in marble so that the patient cannot access any further values it conveys. The therapist, however, can understand that the image is a structuring one and can therefore amplify it, extend it, connect it and return it, as it were, in an elaborated form to the patient, who is unable to perform this 'digestive' function alone.

Some examples

I would like to cite some clinical examples to bring this theme more to life.

A patient with psychotic traits, a very acute and intelligent man, always talks to me about how excessively penetrable he is. Everything creeps inside him and occupies him completely. This constant self-referentiality is actually an attempt to understand where, in his mental and physical space, the sensory data of the day have gone.

One day, he tells me he wants to remove a tattoo he had done on his shoulder, that he now feels encumbered by.

Sudden and powerful thought is triggered in the therapist's mind. The tattoo is a sensory image that has become fixed on the skin and cannot be erased. Every sensory detail writes itself on the patient's skin like a tattoo, changing his external and internal appearance. We both agree on this motif of a fixed image with a sense of relief. The following day, the patient would have the tattoo removed.

The tattoo is an epiphany and a structuring image, that sums up a large amount of data about the patient's functioning: the cutaneous and physical inscription of sensory data, his fixedness, his occupying a space that can no longer be erased, the idea of an accepted and now rejected violence.

Another case

A patient states that she cannot tolerate the kindness and overly warm terms that her therapist, a woman, sometimes uses with her. The patient has a history of an almost sado-masochistic relationship with a brutal and violent mother.

One day, the story of an early episode unfolds: a small animal, of the arachnid family, attached itself to her leg and gave her a long and troublesome illness.

The image of the tick, repulsive and disturbing, gives us both a more precise vision of her relationship with her mother. Too intimate, too indissoluble, but with a mortiferous quality, that injects into the patient both repulsion and identification.

A third example

A severely psychotic patient finds unbearable the memory of a grandmother, who spat out repulsive animals that she felt were invading her. But the image of the spitting appeared later. Before it was a narrative of frightening experiences, repulsion, terror, compassion, pity.

But the spitting brought something new. The repulsive animals were passed on from the body of the grandmother to that of the grandson, leaving an indelible trace in his mouth, which assimilated his body to the cockroach in Kafka's Metamorphosis.

Here the epiphany makes us perceive a different nature with respect to contagion: the invasion of the grandson by the grandmother and his assimilation to her.

Conclusions

I have attempted to describe the function of an epiphanic image,by defining it as a structuring image that encapsulates the characteristics of a subject-object relationship prolonged in time, but with precise traits of fixedness and almost an unmodifiability.

A powerful metaphor could be that of the shirt given to Hercules by his vengeful wife, which burns and consumes him once he has worn it.

It is important to emphasise that although I have used examples taken from severe cases of psychosis, the concept of epiphany goes much further and allows us to shed light on a story with less predictable attributes than those cited.

But in any case, what is most important is to connect the epiphanic image, which, as we have said, must be something surprising, with the relationship between patient and therapist and with the whole context of the patient's life, at least as we know it (Ferro 2006). If we do not do this, we risk to see in the image meanings that do not belong to the patient but to the therapist only.

Once this contextual placement is made, it then becomes possible to return the image to the patient

and begin to work on it together. The epiphanic or structuring image will then be the basis for an explanatory work on the most significant relationships in the patient's life.

Disclosure statement

I have no conflicts of interest to disclose.

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